That was closer to the reality. From the start, the General Staff planners envisioned the operation as one that involved not only the missile troops but also the army, navy, and air force. Khrushchev recalled later: “We considered that if we were indeed to place rockets, then they had to be protected and defended. That required infantry. That is why we decided to send infantry there as well, something like a few thousand men. Antiaircraft equipment was also essential. Then we decided that we also needed artillery to defend the rockets in case the enemy landed parachute troops.” Khrushchev had to look for a senior officer with experience of commanding different branches of armed forces. The status of the newly formed task force was equal if not superior to that of the groups of Soviet armed forces in East Germany and other East European countries. Moreover, the title of “commander in chief” was initially suggested for the leader of the group—a step above “commander,” the title used in Germany. The suggestion was not implemented, and Pliev served with the title “commander,” but the idea that someone be experienced in coordinating different services remained in place. Pliev fit the bill.[10]

There was another feature that distinguished Pliev from his competitors: the minister of defense, Marshal Malinovsky, had known him personally for many years and trusted him. A native of North Ossetia on the Russo-Georgian border, Pliev had joined the Red Army in 1922. A cavalryman to boot, he demonstrated the continued effectiveness of large cavalry formations in modern mechanized warfare during World War II. Soviet tank formations reinforced by Pliev’s cavalry and under his command would make deep raids into German-held territory after the Battle of Stalingrad. Fighting under Malinovsky in 1944, he carried out a surprise raid on Malinovsky’s native city of Odesa and received his first Gold Star of the Soviet Union for liberating that urban center on the Black Sea. He earned his second gold star in the following year when, again under Malinovsky’s command, he led a surprise raid through the Gobi Desert of southern Mongolia toward Beijing, forcing the surrender of Japanese forces there.[11]

In April 1962 Pliev was promoted to the highest rank in the Soviet army short of marshal—General of the Army. At that time he was the commander of the North Caucasus Military District, which covered southern Russia and the autonomous republics of the North Caucasus, including his native North